

Papua New Guinea

Ratio: 3:4 **Adopted:** June 24, 1971 **Usage:** National and Civil

The five stars represent the Southern Cross, but also refer to a local legend about five sisters



Red and black are the predominant colors in the native art of Papua New Guinea

A golden bird of paradise

Australasia and Oceania



Papua New Guinea gained full independence in 1975, following its status as a United Nations Trusteeship under Australian administration.

The Australian administration attempted to introduce Papua New Guinea's first official national flag in 1970. Its choice was a vertically divided flag: blue at the hoist, with the stars of the Southern Cross as in the Australian flag, then white, then green, with a golden bird of paradise. The proposed design was never popular with the local people.

A LOCAL DESIGN

The current flag of yellow and white on black and red was designed by a 15-year-old art student, Susan Karike, and officially accepted in 1971. When Papua New Guinea became independent in 1975, it was retained as the national flag.

THE COLORS OF NATIVE ART

The colors of the field—red and black—were chosen because of their widespread use in the native art of the country. The bird of paradise has long been a local emblem, and its feathers are used for traditional dress and in festivals and ceremonies.

THE SOUTHERN CROSS

The flag is halved diagonally. The lower half features the Southern Cross constellation in white on black, as it would appear in the night sky, over Papua New Guinea. This signifies the link with Australia and also recalls a local legend about five sisters. The red upper half bears a golden bird of paradise in flight.